

palpable. His directness made this an unexpectedly compelling interview for me. Clark began our conversation by telling his story from the time he finished school at the age of 17.



I did my A levels a year early, and left school at the age of 17. I knew nothing about university. No one in my family had been to university.

You came from a working-class background?

I was the third generation, all living in the same council house—government housing is what I guess you would call in the U.S.—on the outskirts of London. I didn't know my father; he didn't hang around. I lived with my mother, brother, and grandparents. My mother was always working, so I was sort of half-raised by my grandparents.

One day, I got a call from Grant, a school friend who now works here—a call for which I am eternally grateful. He was considered one of the posh kids at school because his parents actually owned their own house. “You should come and work in the city,”² Grant said. “There are 25-year-olds earning £50,000.” I didn't know what I wanted to do, but I thought I would go there, and earn some money until I decided what I wanted to be when I grew up. I'm still waiting. I naively thought, *Okay, I will go work in the city then and be a trader*. I didn't even know what a trader was.

Was Grant working as a trader?

He was working as a trading assistant. I had no concept what that meant, either.

What were you doing at the time?

I was working for a hi-fi installation company. I was designing the layout of home stereo system installations, lifting things, and driving a van.

Did you try to get a job in the city?

I wrote lots and lots of places and always got the same answer, “no degree, no interview,” or “no experience, no interview.”

That is exactly what I would have expected.